I said, miserably, "But I can't, Fred. Doubleday is doing my books, and I can't leave them."

Fred thought I could, since I would make far more money with Ballantine.

I thought about it some more and said, with a kind of wan hope, "Well, if Doubleday rejects a book or if it cheats me somehow, I can make the change. But how can I do it if they don't give me cause?"

"If they don't pay you enough money, then that's cause," said Fred.

I remember sitting there in his office quite a while, thinking about

that. It would be great to make a lot of money with my writing, and I would feel silly if all the other writers went on to make a lot of money and left me behind. 7

But then I thought of Brad taking my first book, and going over the galleys with me, and working with me to cure me of overwriting, and of being always kind and helpful, and I had to picture myself saying, "Sorry, Brad, you've been outbid."

So I finally said, "I can't do it, Fred. I'm sorry."

I left, more miserable than you could imagine, for I knew that from a business standpoint I had done the wrong thing.

And yet—though Ballantine Books flourished, it never quite fulfilled that initial hope of making all its writers rich. Doubleday, on the other hand, stayed with me and continued to help me and be kind to me, and do for me every bit, and more, of what I had imagined Ballantine might do for me, and so I had turned out to have made a very clever business decision after all.

I wish I could say it had been because I was an incredibly clever businessman, blessed with an unexampled gift of foresight—but it was nothing of the sort. I made my decision on the perfectly silly emotional ground that Doubleday had been good to me and that I must not return evil for good.

*7

I was getting ready for a longer trip, the longest I had made since I was in the Army and the longest I had ever made voluntarily up to that point. The fact was that I had to go to Chicago. The American Chemical Society was meeting